It could be changing, though. Soon after NEP was announced, the University Grants Commission, the regulatory body for higher education in India, sprung into action to initiate the implementation of its basic framework. A series of radical reforms are under way, such as allowing graduate students to pursue doctorate degrees, doing away with the mandatory PhD requirement to teach in central universities, introducing a common entrance test for admission to undergraduate courses in central university colleges and permitting autonomous colleges to offer online degrees. In April, the UGC issued new norms for Indian universities to collaborate with international varsities and offer twinning courses and degrees. Such collaborations between Indian and international universities were introduced in 2016, but there were few takers as the regulations were considered too complicated. Now, nearly 50 global higher educational institutions from countries such as the UK, Germany, South Africa, Australia and Scotland have expressed interest in collaborating with Indian universities to offer twinning courses and joint and dual degrees.

However, the task is far from done, particularly in ensuring equity in the distribution of quality education. It remains an important concern for students, especially as they aspire to join the country's best universities. And this is where the India Today Group's annual ranking of India's best universities can come to their aid. Not only does it foster spirit of competition among universities but the rich information and data also provide a useful guide for students and their parents.

The survey, conducted by leading Indian market research agency, the Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), has emerged as the definitive word on the academic and infrastructural state of Indian universities. Its wider acceptance and credibility can be gauged by the fact that the number of participating universities has gone up from 120 in 2019 to 160 this year.

If there is one takeaway from this year's rankings, it is how universities from the north and south dominate the top ranks. Among the top 20 government general universities, for instance, seven are from the north and nine from the south. Among the top 20 private general universities, 11 are from the north and seven from the south. The top 10 medical universities are again split between the north and south. Among technical universities, the north corners five of the top 10 positions while the south and east share two each. The distribution is more even in the case of law universities, with the north, east and south having three positions each among the top 10.

More worrying is the gap in the quality of education between government and private universities. Of a total score of 2,000, the score for top 10 general universities in the government category ranges between 1,830 and 1,575. The corresponding range for private universities is 1,611 and 1,356. The top government medical college scores 1,940 while the top private medical college scores 1,440. This gap between government and private universities is visible in the technical stream as well.

With 412 universities making up nearly 40 per cent of the total strength, enhancing the quality of private universities is imperative to cater to the rapidly growing student population. While the authorities have made concerted efforts to ensure affordable and quality education in private institutes of higher education, the India Today Group's rankings aspire to generate cut-throat competition between private and government universities. After all, a transparent annual assessment is a fundamental requirement to ensure that the end user—the student—chooses right. ■

THE UNIVERSITY ECOSYSTEM

TYPE OF UNIVERSITY	TOTAL NUMBER
CENTRAL UNIVERSITIES	54
STATE UNIVERSITIES	455
DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITIES	126
PRIVATE UNIVERSITIES	412
TOTAL	1,047

THE EXPANDING UNIVERSE

Nearly 250 new universities have come up in the past 7 years

YEAR	NO. OF UNIVERSITIES
2015-16	799
2016-17	864
2017-18	903
2018-19	993
2019-20	1,043
2021-22	1,047

161

higher education institutes have been accorded the status of Institutions of National Importance

21

universities have been declared fake by the University Grants Commission. At eight, Delhi has the highest number